

Conventions of Academic Writing

Make Direct and Positive Sentences

You should not use unessential words and phrases. You should avoid unnecessarily long, technical, or unusual words or phrases. Thus, well-constructed sentences are a mark of skill in writing. In writing a report, you should write naturally and directly using familiar words, short sentences with simple constructions.

Presentation

Charts, sections, sub-sections, tables etc. should be labeled adequately. The system of headings and subheadings should be kept simple. The sequence of the sections and subsections should be logical and clear. The introduction, data analysis and findings are to be in the past tense; conclusion in the tense; and recommendations in the future tense.

Use of the First Person

The report is to be written in the third person. The pronouns such as I, my, mine, our, ours, We, us and me should be eliminated from the report. If required to refer to yourself, you use the Words "the writer" or "the investigator".

Use Gender-neutral Language

When writing a research report, it is very important to select terminology which treats both genders equally. You should not make assumptions about one gender as opposed to the other. In such instances, the use of the relevant pronoun, he or she, may be appropriate and even necessary for the reporting of the research.

Avoid Emotional Terms

Instead of writing "Sales increased tremendously", "The increase was fantastic" or "The amazing increase was attributed to... ", simply state the percentage of increase in sales.

Label Opinions

Generally, facts are strongly preferred over opinions. Sometimes, however, opinions add conviction. The opinions of specialists may be available when facts from research are not available. When presenting opinions, you can reveal the background and identity of the person presenting the opinion. Sometimes, data are such that no solid conclusion can be drawn, or a variety of explanations could exist. In such cases, opinions can strongly substantiate your explanations and conclusions.

Use of Notes and Footnotes

It is sometimes necessary to include in a project report additional material which it is felt to be inappropriate to place in the main text. This kind of material may be information which is supplementary to the principal arguments of the text. Such material may be included in footnotes at the bottom of the relevant page, or in notes at the end of each chapter.

Non-English Terms and Expressions

Non-English terms are sometimes used in project research reports. The terms which are used regularly in English should not be italicized. However, an expression such as *chakka jam* would probably be italicized. When using an expression from another language, it is worth considering whether it is likely to be understood by most readers.

English and American Spellings

The issue which occurs most commonly in academic writing is the selection of the form of verbs which can end in either 'ise' or 'ize'. In English academic writing, the latter form is the norm. Examples of such regularly used words in research include hypothesize, synthesize, and socialize. However, both these formats are equally acceptable. You should use one spelling format consistently.

Abbreviations

Abbreviations should be used sparingly. When inserted in the text to any great extent, they have the effect of breaking up the text, and making it more difficult to read. The reader may forget the meaning of some of the abbreviations and need to turn back regularly to consult the glossary. When the abbreviation is used for the first time, then the full form of the term should be given first, followed by the abbreviation in brackets afterwards. From that point onwards, the abbreviation may be used on its own.

Confidentiality and Anonymity

As far as possible, you should try to maintain confidentiality and anonymity. If the research involves any type of case study, then it is possible to use fictional names. The main advantage in this is that it gives the report an air of reality.

Consistency

While writing, consistency in the spellings, abbreviations, style, etc. should be maintained. It is therefore to make a choice of format, and then to abide by that choice throughout the report. Even slight variations in practice, can be an irritant for the evaluators of your thesis.

Typing the Research Report

Paper

For the purpose of typing white Xerox paper may be used. The size of the paper should be 8.6 by 11 inches. Only one side of the paper is to be used.

Chapter Page

The chapter number is centered about two inches from the top of the page. Following to spaces below should be the title of the chapter in capital letters. The first line of the text should begin four spaces below that title.

Margins

Margins indicate the boundaries of the text. APA specifies 1-inch margins all around (top, bottom, left, and right).

Spacing

The text of the report should be double-spaced. Indented, quotations and footnotes should be single-spaced. Same style and size of font should be used throughout the report.

Page Number

Page number should come at the top right hand corner of the page, one inch from the top edge and one inch from the right-hand edge of the page. The first line of the text should be two spaces below the page number.

Pagination

Pages should be numbered consecutively in Arabic numerals from the first page of the text to the end of the manuscript (including the appendices). The pages in the introductory sections (preface, table of contents etc.) should be numbered with small Roman numerals i, ii, iii, iv, v, etc., one inch from the bottom of the page. All page numbers should stand alone without periods, hyphens or dashes.

Proofreading

The manuscript should be read critically, searching for inaccurate statements, wrong entries' omissions and inconsistencies. After verifying and locating errors in quotations, footnotes, tables, figures, paragraphing, sentence structure, headings, spellings, style, bibliography, mark the copy to provide the typist with necessary directions for providing a satisfactory transcript.

LAYOUT OF THE RESEARCH REPORT

Anybody, who is reading the research report, must necessarily be conveyed enough about the study so that he can place it in its general scientific context, judge the adequacy of its methods and thus form an opinion of how seriously the findings are to be taken. For this purpose there is the need of proper layout of the report means as to what the research report should contain. A comprehensive layout of the research report should comprise (a) preliminary pages; (b) main text; and (c) the end matter.

(a) Preliminary Pages

In its preliminary pages the report should carry a title and date, followed by acknowledgements in the form of 'preface' or 'foreword'. Then there should be a table of contents followed by List of tables and illustrations.

(b) Main Text

The main text provides the complete outline of the research report along with all details. Title of the research study is repeated at the top of the first page of the main text and then follows the other details on pages numbered consecutively, beginning with the second page. Each main section of the report should begin on a new page. The main text of the report should have the following sections: (i) Introduction; (ii) Statement of findings and recommendations; (iii) The results; (iv) The implications drawn from the results; and (v) The summary.

(i) Introduction

The purpose of introduction is to introduce the research project to the readers. It should contain a clear statement of the objectives of research i.e., enough background should be given to make clear to the reader why the problem was considered worth investigating. A brief summary of other relevant research may also be stated so that the present study can be seen in that context. The hypotheses of study, if any, and the definitions of the major concepts employed in the study should be explicitly stated in the introduction of the report.

The methodology adopted in conducting the study must be fully explained. How was the study carried out? What was its basic design? If the study was an experimental one, then what were the experimental manipulations? If the data were collected by means of questionnaires or interviews, then exactly what questions were asked (The questionnaire or interview schedule is usually given in an appendix). If measurements were based on observation, then what instructions were given to the observers? Regarding the sample used in the study the reader should be told: Who were the subjects? How many were there? How were they selected? All these questions are crucial for estimating the probable limits of generalizability of the findings.

The statistical analysis adopted must also be clearly stated. In addition to all this, the scope of the study should be stated and the boundary lines be demarcated. The various limitations, under which the research project was completed, must also be narrated.

(ii) Statement of findings and recommendations

After introduction, the research report must contain a statement of findings and recommendations in non-technical language so that it can be easily understood by all concerned. If the findings happen to be extensive, at this point they should be put in the summarized form.

(iii) Results

A detailed presentation of the findings of the study, with supporting data in the form of tables and charts together with a validation of results, is the next step in writing the main text of the report. This generally comprises the main body of the report, extending over several chapters. The result section of the report should contain statistical summaries and reductions of the data rather than the raw data. All the results should be presented in logical sequence. All relevant results must find a place in the report. But how one is to decide about what is relevant is the basic question. Quite often guidance comes primarily from the research problem and from the hypotheses. But ultimately the researcher must rely on his own judgment in deciding the outline of his report.

(iv) Implications of the results Toward the end of the main text, the researcher should again put down the results of his research clearly and precisely. He should, state the implications that flow from the results of the study, for the general reader is interested in the implications for understanding the human behavior. Such implications may have three aspects as stated below:

- (a) A statement of the inferences drawn from the present study which may be expected to apply in similar circumstances.
- (b) The conditions of the present study which may limit the extent of legitimate generalizations of the inferences drawn from the study.
- (c) The relevant questions that still remain unanswered or new questions raised by the study along with suggestions for the kind of research that would provide answers for them.

(v) Summary: It has become customary to conclude the research report with a very brief summary, resting in brief the research problem, the methodology, the major findings and the major conclusions drawn from the research results.

(c) End Matter

At the end of the report, appendices should be enlisted in respect of all technical data such as questionnaires, sample information, mathematical derivations and the like ones. Bibliography of sources consulted should also be given. Index (an alphabetical listing of names, places and topics along with the numbers of the pages in a book or report on which they are mentioned or discussed) should invariably be given at the end of the report. The value of index lies in the fact that it works as a guide to the reader for the contents in the report.